D Mich 5 Grammar notes

Expressing intention and the hidden future

- There are various ways in French of **expressing intention**. Other than just using the future tense, or the present tense of ALLER + infinitive, you can choose from the following expressions:
  - **Penser** FAIRE qc — *to be thinking of doing sthg*
  - **Compter** FAIRE qc — *to plan to do sthg*
  - **Avoir l'intention de** FAIRE qc — *to intend doing sthg*
  - **Envisager de** FAIRE qc — *to be contemplating doing sthg*
  - **Songer à** FAIRE qc — *to be considering doing sthg*
  - **Caresser l'idée de** FAIRE qc — *to be toying with the idea of doing sthg*
- You will remember (E Mich 3) that sometimes French needs to use a **future tense where in English a present tense is used**. This is usually after temporal conjunctions such as **QUAND** and **DÈS QUE** if the main verb refers to an action which is in the future. If the main verb does not refer to an action in the future, the present tense is used as in English.

> - *Quand je quitterai l'école, j'irai à l'université.*
> - *Quand je me couche, je lis.*

- Sometimes **English uses a form similar to the future tense where no reference to the future is intended**. Rather it is to make an offer/(firm)request/ "Shall I help you?" + "Will you shut the door?" + "Will you be quiet!". In the negative, it may also express a determination or refusal: "The dog won't eat anything, he must be ill" + "I will not be spoken to in that tone of voice". **In all of these examples, French uses VOULOIR in the present tense.**

> - *Voulez-vous que je vous aide? Voulez vous ouvrir la porte?*
> - *Veux-tu te taire! Le chien ne veut rien manger: il doit être malade*
> - *Je ne veux pas qu'on me parle sur ce ton!*

The passive voice

- **What is the passive voice?** Most sentences tell you that "somebody did something" i.e. the order is SUBJECT – VERB – OBJECT: "*Pierre sold the bike – Pierre a vendu le vélo*". In this example, the verb is active. Quite often, especially in English, you can turn this round and say "*the bike was sold by Pierre – Le vélo a été vendu par Pierre*". In this case, the object becomes the subject, and the person who performs the verb is called "the **agent**". The verb is now in the passive voice.

- **How do you form the passive?**
  - **Take the relevant tense of the verb ÊTRE**
  - **Add the past participle which has to agree with the subject.**
  - **"by" is translated with "par". You do not always need an agent.**

  - *La viande a été mangée par le chien*
  - *Le travail est corrigé par le professeur*
  - *La fille aurait été punie par sa mère*
  - *La maison a été construite récemment*
  - *Les garçons seront punis par leur père*
  - *La maison a dû être vendue*

- **Can any verb be put into the passive voice?** No. Any verb that takes an indirect object (**à qn** – *donner à qn*, or **de qn**, *se souvenir de qn*) must avoid the passive voice. This is done by using the active voice, and having the pronoun "ON" be the subject of the verb, though it refers to nobody in particular.

  - *I was given a present – On m'a donné un cadeau* – **donner à qn**
  - *She will be remembered – On se souviendra d'elle* – **se souvenir de qn**
  - *He was told that – On lui a dit que* – **dire à qn**
  - *They were advised to – On leur a conseillé de* – **conseiller à qn**

To take sb/sthg and to bring sb/sthg to a place

- **Translating these verbs often causes difficulty.** Never use PRENDRE to refer to people, and avoid it to refer to moving things from one place to another.

- The French verbs **to take** to a place are **emmener qn** and **emporter qc**
- The French verbs **to bring** to a place are **amener qn** and **apporter qc**

- An easy distinction to make is that verbs ending –mener are those which might be used to "lead people by the hand", and those ending in –porter are those which might be used to carry things.

  - *Oui je viens à la fête. Veux tu que j'apporte du vin?*
  - *Je peux amener un ami aussi? Mon père va nous y amener en voiture.*
  - *Ma mère emmène ma soeur à l'école tous les matins. Mon père nous a emmenés tous au restaurant. Je vais emmener ma copine au cinéma.*
  - *Emporte ces chaises, on ne va pas les utiliser.*
  - *Pizzas à emporter*